

# Text, Data & Different Formats

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

## 1. Learning goal

Integrate information from prose, tables, charts, fact sheets, timelines, or other formats and determine whether the formats support, qualify, or contradict each other.

## 2. What this skill means

Different formats may answer different parts of the same question. A paragraph may make a claim while a table shows whether the pattern exists. Good readers translate both formats into the same comparison before drawing a conclusion.

## 3. Do not confuse it with

Do not treat a table as decoration or assume one striking number represents the whole pattern. Also do not force two formats to agree when the data actually qualify the prose.

## 4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "How does the table support the article?", "Which claim is supported by the data?", "What does the fact sheet add?", or "Which statement accurately combines both formats?"

## 5. Repeatable method

- Identify the claim or question in the prose.
- Read table/visual labels before reading individual numbers.
- Compare the correct rows, columns, dates, or categories.
- State what the second format adds: support, detail, limitation, or contradiction.
- Choose a conclusion that uses both formats without overstating either one.

## 6. Worked example

An article says shuttle crowding is concentrated between 8:00 and 8:30 a.m. A table shows average passenger loads of 42 at 7:30, 61 at 8:00, 67 at 8:20, and 44 at 9:00 on buses designed for 55 riders.

Question: How does the table relate to the claim?

Reasoning: The two peak-time rows exceed capacity, while the earlier and later rows do not. The data support a concentrated peak rather than all-morning crowding.

Best answer: It supports the claim that crowding is concentrated around 8:00-8:30 a.m.

## 7. Common traps

- Reading the largest number without checking its label.
- Using one format while ignoring a limitation in the other.
- Saying the data prove a broader claim than the categories actually cover.

## 8. Diagnostic help

- If your answer mentions a number but not what it measures, return to the labels.
- If the prose says "often" and your answer says "always," you probably overstated the combined evidence.
- If formats appear to conflict, check whether they are measuring different groups or time periods.

## 9. Quick check

A memo says complaints are highest on Mondays. A table shows 34 Monday complaints, 18 Tuesday, 17 Wednesday, 16 Thursday, and 19 Friday.

What does the table contribute?

**Check yourself:** It supports the memo by showing Monday has the highest count among the listed weekdays.